

# Ministry Snapshot at a Glance

**Pastor Bert Han** · Birmingham Chinese Evangelical Church (BCEC) · Birmingham, UK

CCCOWE 2026 Explore360 · "The Evolving Chinese Church Around the Globe"

**Who's speaking.** Born in Southern California, in UK Chinese-church ministry for 30 years — early years with COCM, the last 24 at BCEC in England's second-largest city, now senior pastor. Four sites, five services: two Cantonese, one Mandarin, two English in Birmingham, plus a Cantonese/Mandarin congregation in Telford.

## ▪ Who Are the People? Waves — and then a flood.

- **Founding wave (late 1970s–80s):** Southeast Asian and Hong Kong immigrants in the catering trade. BCEC was born in a restaurant basement — Pastor Frank Jern ran Bible studies at 1 or 2 a.m. after the takeaways closed, as an alternative to the casino.
- **The scholars:** the Mandarin congregation grew from mainland students who came for master's and PhDs and stayed.
- **The English congregation:** international students who stayed plus local-born Chinese heritage — the perennial challenge of every Chinese heritage church in the English-speaking world.
- **The BNO wave (2021–now) — the story dominating the UK Chinese church:** Britain's British National Overseas visa opened a path to residency for Hong Kongers. Roughly 200,000 applicants UK-wide; about 20,000 in the Birmingham region. Many chose neighborhoods from **YouTube videos** by Hong Kong influencers: "We found Hong Kongers were making videos about this area, so we all moved there."

## ▪ The Defining Tension: a merger, not a revival.

BCEC had been **quietly sunseting** its Cantonese ministry — retirees, no musicians, drifting toward YouTube worship. Then, overnight, it was flooded. "As soon as we opened up church again, it was packed... every week it was 30 or 40 new people." **From one Cantonese service headed for YouTube to five Cantonese services in four years.**

But it felt less like revival than a corporate acquisition: a large company moving all its staff into a small one overnight. A 30-person congregation that built the church over decades suddenly hosted 80 newcomers from Hong Kong megachurches — high expectations ("Why is your building so small? Build seven stories!"), different denominational cultures. Original members felt like strangers in their own church.

Underneath it: **grief.** Many sold everything; some didn't tell their children until they were already on the way; some can't return. "Hong Kong culture is dying... I look at my daughter — she's not going to be a Hong Konger at all." That is not a political statement to correct. It is grief to receive.

## ▪ What a Healthy Church Looks Like (Bert's two questions)

- 1 **Does the congregation value Christ over its cultural defaults?** "Chinese culture — we're really good at discipline, and shame, and math. But we're not so good at grace." Are we generous? Possessive? Is family held healthily or idolatrously?
- 2 **Can each language congregation evangelize, encourage, and empower in its own community?** Unity is not uniformity. Not parent-and-child (where the child never grows up) but **three siblings** who bless each other and learn from each other's strengths.

The result is rarer than people admit: genuinely multi-lingual, multi-generational, multi-national, multi-class, politically diverse — "more actual diversity than most 'multiracial' majority-culture churches."

## ▪ The Insight That Lands

Bert refuses the "what can the Chinese church offer Britain?" frame. "Any church making genuine disciples provides integral value to the society it's in." His bottom line: **"If you make a church that you like going to..."** — he's on sabbatical and already misses his. More hopeful than anxious. The UK Chinese church hasn't arrived at equilibrium; it's in the middle of something.